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Tim Ries

Tim Ries is a saxophonist, keyboardist and composer who has led a fascinating career working with the top names in jazz and popular music. He has enjoyed a visible gig as a member of the Rolling Stones touring horn section, and embraces the opposite end of the spectrum by leading his own jazz combos.

Tim was interviewed in Utica, New York on March 19, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: It's my pleasure to have Tim Ries with me today for the Fillius Jazz Archive. Would you like to hear what Wiki says about you?

TR: Oh boy. Okay?'

MR: Okay.

TR: Who's Wiki?

MR: He gets around. So Wikipedia says, "His universe of work as a composer, arranger, and instrumentalist ranges from rock to jazz to experimental to ethno to fusions of respective genres thereof."

TR: Well, Wiki can be correct.

MR: I think it is.

TR: Yeah. I mean, yeah.

MR: I wanted to ask you, this thought occurred to me in the last couple of days because I visited your website and there's three particular videos that you had up there of varying kinds of music. And then hearing your set, the way you played and your set list. I wondered if, as a child, you were an extraordinarily curious boy?

TR: I was. I grew up in Michigan and my father played the trumpet and my mother played piano. I had three sisters, they all took piano lessons. And it's funny because my father also worked at a factory, as many people in Michigan did, but on the weekends played gigs. So when I was a little kid he would take me to his gigs, so I was like really small. And I would go and he usually had a band of one or two saxophones in the band, piano and/or accordion, bass, drums, guitar, you know, and so he would sing and play the trumpet. And it was like a band that would play for parties and weddings and stuff like that. So as a little kid, and it was always the weddings and parties I would be part of, you know, because I would always know some other little kids who would be at the party. So I would be there running around but then hearing the band. And of course my dad, I of course loved him dearly, he's been gone 30 years. But I would sit there at the end of the stage and watch him and look at the saxophones and so I wanted to start playing trumpet like he did. So I started that. And then I think he thought maybe he would have to replace

one of his saxophone players so he was pushing me more towards hey, maybe — would you like to play the saxophone. So one day he brought a saxophone home like you know for a birthday or something like that. And I was quite young so I was starting to sit in with him when I was ten years old. So I was already curious about the music that he played, which was mostly older music like the swing era, like old jazz standards. But then he would also incorporate a couple of rock tunes, because younger people would want to play, you know "Proud Mary" or one of those rock-like, and he had to entertain the people. So I saw what it was like to play music and have to do different kinds of things, not just what you maybe liked but what the people might like. But then growing up in the Detroit area, when I was still too young to drive he would drive me to Detroit to sit in with musicians and then to Toledo, Ohio which was very close, and sitting in with like great jazz musicians. And there were so many of the Motown people that never left. When Motown moved to California they just stayed in Detroit and they were like fantastic jazz musicians. So I got to hear and play and sit in with all these great musicians. So I was always being introduced to great musicians and my dad would then have the musicians come back to our house and we would have jam sessions until five, six o'clock in the morning. And my mother would cook. So I was fall asleep on the couch to like this great music. And I remember as a kid like being, I don't know like ten, eleven, twelve years old Saturday mornings watching "Soul Train." Because that was like for me, I loved it. It was like listening to the greatest music ever. You know like I'm seeing the dancing and you know you'd see this little white kid who loved "Soul Train." It was just like all music was good. You know it was like as if it was like essential. And I loved Stevie Wonder of course, Aretha, the Temptations, the Four Tops, and I got a chance then to play with all these people when I was older. So it was such a cool thing growing up. And so we had this big house with a lot of property, so I would go practice outside. So I had the advantage of being in a quiet like area, but then close enough to a bigger city to hang out with musicians and learn from them. So that was really amazing. So I was quite curious as a young person. And you know my dad played the trumpet but he would come home from his day job and sit at the piano, and he wasn't trained as a pianist but then he would just kind of improvise and kind of compose this stuff. I remember being a little kid and I would be in there and I would watch him, not knowing what he was doing. And then he would leave and I would just sit at the piano and try to imitate that vibe. Because I think it was his way of just escaping the world, the workday, and that was his release. And I saw that in him. Like he was different on the piano than he was even on the trumpet, or just he was in this other world and I remember like that's — he never said anything I just saw it. And it was like how do I capture that? And then my oldest sister, who was taking piano lessons, right, studying the piano — I wasn't studying piano, I was

just trying to get that vibe. She came in, "What are you playing? That's just nonsense" you know because I was just improvising. And because she said that it was like oh yeah well then I would do more.

MR: Well I was just thinking that now, because I'm wondering if you learned how to improvise before you had any theoretical basis for what you were doing?

TR: I did. And just I think to capture mostly that feeling of seeing him, because I had an older brother who died and he was the oldest and I was the youngest. So I often wonder if, me having three children, I can't imagine that happening. So I wonder also if that was his going into that other world or something. But I just — he was very different at the piano than — on the trumpet he was like beautiful sound, amazing tone. In fact I remember as a little kid being on one of his gigs, and it was a dance gig. And he always had three, four, five hundred people, there was huge amounts of people. And what would often be the case with that period is like people would go hear musicians play and then you know you'd see people dancing and then they would get close to the bandstand and they would just watch the band, and they would kind of hear whoever was taking a solo or something. And my dad wasn't a heavy improviser but one of the most beautiful tones and just singing through the instrument. And I remember this young couple, maybe in their twenties and maybe they were going to get married or something but they were dancing in the front. And they stopped in front of the stage and were watching my father play. And he was playing a melody to a ballad. And I remember both of them started crying. And I thought to myself my dad just playing a melody made somebody cry. So I think before the notes and how, without impressing anybody with your technique just the idea that music really can capture this heavy emotional, you know, seeing him going into that place on the piano but also then channeling that on the trumpet too. So you know and then a neighbor who also played the trumpet, and I was starting trying to like how do I improvise, how do I do this. And I saw these fake books with the music. And he came over and he played the trumpet but they also could play piano. And he sat down and it was like looked at the fake book and it was like I said, "How are you doing that?" He goes, "Oh this is super easy. This is the bass note, I just play the bass note on the left, bass and fifth and seventh and this is the root." I'm like, "That's it?" He goes, "Yeah." Then it was like a whole new world. Like oh now I can start figuring out these chords." And then there was a university near my house, my dad took me to that, and I met with this professor in high school and he started scheduling improvisation lessons, and he played the organ and piano and trumpet and trombone, and he was a very musical guy named Mike Lorenz. He was great. And that was it. It was kind of like opening the door to like now, I get the theoretical idea of it plus I know the emotional aspect of it that like

now theoretically what is this chord, how do you do that, and then to dissect the chord and then I started composing.

MR: I'm not sure how to ask this but after hearing you play, which was really terrific last night, I should tell our viewers it was in Utica, New York at a cool little place called The Other Side. It seems to me you have abundant technique to play whatever you want. I'm going to go from that premise. So is the challenge not so much how to play it but what to think of? What is something tonight that I can do that I haven't done repeatedly, and if that statement is sort of true, where do your ideas come from?

TR: Well thank you for the kind words. It was a really cool place to play actually, The Other Side, and it was a nice gallery with art work and stuff. And then it was filled with people but with 60 — it was like packed but it's a small place. But really, talking to people before, during the break and then afterwards really, it's a kind of a cool thing about jazz or this improvised music is that those people were there to really hear music and they stayed, and then talking to them and just you realize that this music is really about community in a sense not only on the stage but then a small audience you get that more than you can in a big arena or a big theater, where you can really engage with the people, like local people. And get to know them. And that feeling is really cool. But as far as the technique and what to play while improvising, and what not to do — you know it's almost what not to do in a sense. But the idea like do you know as an individual, a person, whatever instrument that you're playing there's all the years that it takes to get to the place where you can be able to facilitate with the ideas that you have. So the more technique you have, like someone like John Coltrane or Freddie Hubbard or you know, Art Tatum or somebody with just the most incredible technique and you hear that and you just realize that the true brilliant maestros of the music from the past and there are so many, you know it's almost like okay that's there and I'm probably never going to reach that level. I'm trying. I'm trying to reach the level of Coltrane and Charlie Parker and Lester Young. That's been set, that standard of brilliance. So I'm trying to attain that in my practicing and trying to develop a technique so that I can get there. You know so I'm trying to reach the mountaintop. And it took me a long time to realize okay that's there and I'm going to try to get there but I'm going to be satisfied with what I'm doing today, so not judging myself as I'm playing, which is really hard. So as you are that day kind of playing whatever happens. And I truly believe that music — and maybe it's 'cause of my father and seeing that vibe is like I think that the music is there. It's already in the atmosphere or it's coming from a high spiritual place, that if you are accepting of that, if you just allow it to come through you and don't get in the way of it, not to diminish the technique. So you need technique to be able to like play that note in tune, so you need the technique for just the rudimentary aspect of the instrument. But then that's just technique.

Then you have to just allow the music to happen. And that's what's the beautiful part about improvised music and jazz is that then you also hear the drummer do something or Ron last night playing the organ, okay the way he chorded it, or like that connection you have, the conversation. So then it's a combination of like accepting what's coming in, accepting what's happening around you, and then the feeling of the room, actually when you kind of just sense the vibes from the people. There's all that combination it plays a part of it. And you know I think last night was just really special because you know playing with good musicians in a cool place with good people there, it all adds, that all comes together.

MR: It was clear to me that you understand the importance and the power of space and dynamics. Because there was a number of times, one time when you were playing — you played the melody to "Bye-Bye Blackbird." And there was all those like holes in there. And you know Ron was playing a little bit behind you but I don't hear people do that that much. And I wonder why you did it and I wondered is it because of this audience — it's very quiet in there. And those silences, man, are very —

TR: Well it's often what you don't play which is more powerful. You know? Giving that space in thought but also to allow the other musicians around to give him time to add his thing. So I think that's that. I do my best, I still, of the people who leave the most space, of course Miles Davis and Wayne Shorter and those incredible, I still am trying to get to that place. Like if you see Wayne Shorter's group play often he will just play a couple of notes and just like stand there for a long period of time. And it's that whole time, like okay now what is he going to play. And it's pretty special. So those memories of like okay, and you have this period of time, like I say. So you can fill up every space and like play all the technique you have but what does that mean? It's like okay there's a lot of other saxophone players who have way more technique than me. I feel like I have a decent amount of technique but I don't need to show it all the time. So I try to think first of all the melody and I'm trying to, like my father, I'm trying to sing through the instrument, I'm trying to make it like just say a very well known song like that think about Ella or Sarah Vaughan or somebody singing it you know, like how would I sing this? You know?

MR: When you're improvising is there such a thing as a mistake for you?

TR: Well I'm not thinking about that at the time. I'm not thinking about, because then if you get in that mindset then if you think about the mistake then you're in that mistake, it means like — so if that takes over where you're thinking about the mistakes rather than just the time that you're doing this, then you inhibit not only that second that you're in but then the upcoming thing. So I try not — of course if I listen, if I listen back to — if I recorded it, listen back I'd go uh, then you analyze and you're your own worst critic in a

way. I try not to get in the way of that while playing because then — and it took me actually I'm now 62, it took me until I was almost 50 I think before somebody like let's say last night. I finished the concert and many people came up and we were talking. "Oh thank you for the night, it was great, it was a lovely concert." You know all the compliments. Now I can say, "Thank you very much. I appreciate your kind words." And I'm able to now accept the compliment that somebody had a good time. Because up until that point until I was like 50 I would be like in my head I'm thinking, "Really? Like you enjoyed that? Because didn't you hear those mistakes?" All of those things, that's in our own minutiae of our own psyche. I don't need to involve people with that. Because I don't need to like, my own critic of myself, I don't need to. Now I can just say I share this time with you, and like I was talking about before, you were a part of that experience too because that person changed maybe the way I play because I look out in the audience and if I'm talking a little bit before you have a connection with the — so I don't want to ruin that experience for somebody. And so I don't want to get in my own way, which I can, but I try my best to push aside the critique. It's difficult.

MR: Yeah. You don't want to make someone regret giving you a compliment like didn't you hear that high note I went for and I didn't get? It's counterproductive.

TR: Yeah. So I try to stay away from myself and the judging. And certainly at the time of the mistake, because then you're really trapped. Because the whole thing about improvisation, you're trying to move forward. You're trying to like, you don't want to be stuck in two seconds ago, you want to be really in the now. That's the idea, like to capture that moment right now.

MR: Do you think you play differently when the length of your improvisation is open ended? Like last night you pretty much can decide as you're playing how many choruses you're going to do, where if you're playing a solo with a band that — you're not leading it, perhaps you know I need to limit myself. So is there a thought process that you take that into account? Like I'm going to do two choruses so do you play differently if you have a time limit?

TR: Yes. I mean well for instance last night it was more open-ended and I didn't have to limit, as you said, limit myself. I could do one, two, three or four or five. Like there was a period where that accordion player, Al, came up and sat in right. So now we're incorporating a guy who does polka music with the accordion, because Ron Oswanski also is an amazing accordion player and can do the polkas, he grew up in a Polish household and he played all that stuff. But he also can improvise and play jazz, he's incredible. So I called him and I said, "Are you going to bring your accordion?" He goes, "Well." I said, "Well bring it, maybe we'll do a duet." And then before the gig he introduced me to Al. I said, "Well Al would you come and join us?" And I'm trying to

figure out what — so then we did this Ukrainian polka because of the Ukrainian situation. But Ron and I had done, I had to produce an album for Ron and we did that song on his record but we did it kind of like as a North African kind of vibe combined with this polka. So we tried to do that last night with Al but then on that I didn't really improvise. I kind of let Al — which I played the melody with him and then just a little tiny solo, Ron would play a little solo, so just it was more about how do we feature, how do we make him like that's his moment rather than my thing. It's just like okay well we're going to be part of your world now. So but yeah, I try not to worry too much about it. For instance like if I'm playing with the Rolling Stones I'm improvising every night on "Miss You" this famous song of theirs. But that solo is when Mick is out front in front of 50,000 people and he's moving and dancing. So I'm watching when he takes the mic and starts the next verse, right? So my solo could be eight bars, it could be twelve, could be sixteen, could be — depending on his — so I'm actually just watching him thinking well sometimes occasionally I might go out a little bit too much jazz or whatever, but I try to really retain more of like I'm playing almost like rhythm guitarish things with a little bit of like — but I'm looking, okay my solo ends when he starts the verse. So I'm trying to like figure at the end of a phrase to like end so that he is comfortable starting. So then I'm really — it's not so much about me soloing it's about me playing these lines, riffing a little bit and then watching him move and then okay my solo is based on, and also because I love flamenco so a lot of the time when I'm playing with dancers I'm like watching the dancer and imitating the dance of flamenco that's changing the way I play. So I don't mind that. I don't feel it's limiting. I feel it's — that's the conversation.

MR: Yeah. That's an astute player required for that kind of thing I think. And your solos, like that particular solo that's probably like a one chord vamp?

TR: Right. That was two chords, but yeah.

MR: Yeah. Is that harder or easier, or is it both? I mean if you were playing "Groovin' High" and then you play, over here you've got a two chord vamp, which is more challenging?

TR: You know they both have their challenges, not challenges but I don't want to say limitations, they both have their differences in the sense that with "Groovin' High" I'm just playing with a jazz group and I can kind of — do I defer to Dizzy and Bird, thinking about that, or do I just try to do my thing on that song? But I'm still trying to do my thing also on "Miss You" because the original song with Bobby Keys I'm not playing like Bobby but I don't want to be too far from it because I'm riffing, and again I'm playing because Mick is out there in front of the people so the show is about supporting the Stones as best I can and so I'm in a supportive role in that way and then with "Groovin' High" I'm I guess freer in a sense because I'm not worrying about so much okay this person is coming in singing the verse so maybe it's slightly freer that way.

MR: But there's more chord — there's a chord progression to pay more attention to.

TR: Oh yeah, that's true, of course, yeah. Yeah and then it's like in these chords in this way how do I want to — how far do I want to take this.

MR: We might as well talk about the Stones a little bit as long as we're here. When you got the call or whatever to join, was there any question of whether you would or not?

TR: Well weirdly enough when I got the call it was my friends who live in New York who had played in the horn section with the Stones, Mike Davis on trombone, Kent Smith on trumpet, and Andy Snitzer, the saxophone player who left the Stones to go with Paul Simon. So he was leaving, they needed a guy who played sax, piano, organ, which I can do that stuff. So when Andy was leaving they got together and decided that a few of the musicians that they knew who could be best suited for that, and they called me. It was like the call was kind of out of the blue. I wasn't expecting to get the call. And they said, "Would you be interested in the gig." I'm like, "Well yeah, sure, that sounds amazing." But you know growing up as a child I wasn't thinking okay when I'm 25 when I'm 30, that's the gig I'm going for because it was just — but when it happened it was just like one of those things where those interesting surprises in life are sometimes the best. And you know, in a way sometimes I tell this to students, you have to be prepared for those calls. Like you may not get a call the second time. Like whatever that may be for, like whether it's the Rolling Stones or for a jazz group, are you ready for the gig in the sense that you've done your preparation, you've worked your butt off and practiced and you're ready for the gig.

MR: Were there written horn parts for you?

TR: Yeah there were specific horn parts, yes, because there were two saxes, trumpet, trombone and Bobby Keys had been with him for years so yeah, there were certain — and then the improvised things were different but then the horn section parts were — and then the keyboard parts and the organ were very kind of specific. So yeah I had to learn what those were.

MR: How about the intensity of those shows? The volume, the lights — I don't have a question here I'm sort of just trying to imagine it. Because I spent some time in a very loud rock band and I'm wondering what that was like for you?

TR: I mean it's pretty amazing just being in a place where there's 50, 60, 70 thousand people just the volume of the people, right? I mean so screaming and yelling and like you know the cheering and singing along, I mean that volume even without us playing is already a lot so then you combine that with an array of guitars, basses and amplifiers and all that stuff. But the good thing is that we're spaced out quite a bit on stage, and I have my own monitor so I can have in my mix I'll have a little keyboard, a little bit of voice, a little bit of this, so I can kind of choose what I want. But you know I'm careful but my — you

know I have tinnitus which is ringing in my ears, but I got that well before the Stones playing in big bands, you know being in front of a trumpet or trombone player right by your head. I mean that's pretty loud already. So it's got its volume but I luckily can hear what I want from my mix so I'm pretty okay.

MR: Do the Rolling Stones, the core group, do they ever mess up in a concert?

TR: I mean I would — I think they would say yeah but so what — I think that their mess-ups or their little things that happen that are like you know slightly different, they're okay with that. You know for instance I remember once Keith — Keith has many guitars and he's got a guitar tech that tunes like for almost every tune has a new guitar because it's a different tuning. Like not every tune is — so this tune will be that. I remember once he got a guitar and put it on and either he went to the next song or it was the wrong guitar but he went and played the chord and it was like the wrong thing and Mick was like, "It's the wrong chord, Mate" or something. You know it was just like — but then it was just laughable. It was like okay give me this guitar and then say — but you know those things happen. I mean they're human you know? But I must say before we play the concerts we rehearse for a number of weeks and we've rehearsed let's say 90 of their songs, then down to 70 then down to 60, then by the time the tour starts let's say we have 40 songs ready to go out and every night we play like 20, 21, 22 songs. And they'll introduce, you know, maybe of the 21 songs maybe 16 or 15 are always there and then they'll intersperse like you know different ballad or a different this or different that. So then we put in those ones that we've rehearsed. In this city we'll do that song or something like that. So they're prepared in a sense, I mean they're really ready. And of course the lighting and the staging and the you know everything set. They have this great, you know, oh this tune has that light and this — and everything's like — it's a show. It's like a major production with hundreds of people that are traveling with us you know getting things prepared. The sound person and the back line people. It's a massive like undertaking. So they're as together as they can be. Any of the mistakes are more looked at as just part of life.

MR: Do they ever make game time decisions like change their mind about a song list — "Let's insert this now?"

TR: Well we don't get the song list until like right before the show. So like day of the show will be kind of like — show's at — like maybe by six or something then we get the set list. So every city has its own reasons for that song. Maybe we're in Detroit and we're going to do a Motown tune. Maybe we're in Nashville or maybe we'll do one of their country things. You know so it depends on where we are. And Chuck Leavell is the musical director. So he'll look at okay the last time we were in this city we did these songs so not to repeat something when we went back to Cleveland — we did that last

time so let's do this one this time. So it's kind of like, so like we do a sound check and then by six here's the set list. Oh cool, we're doing this.

MR: Anything that would surprise us about Mick and Keith Richards?

TR: You know it's like well luckily I've known them now for 23 years so it's like as I said, they're really prepared, I mean you know Keith has a guitar in his hand all the time and they're always like working on stuff, new songs, they're constantly writing, so and he's reading books you know, Ronnie Wood — he's like a great artist and he's painting all the time. Charlie Watts who was a huge jazz fan you know, he actually also was an artist and so he has these beautiful sketches that whenever he got to a hotel when we flew to a different city he would arrive and the first thing he would do before he did anything else was unpack and then he would do a drawing of the room where he was, of that hotel. And then the view out of the window. So I'm sure there's thousands and thousands of these and I luckily got to see some of these which are amazing. I hope that one day maybe there'll be a gallery that'll show these. So besides his love for jazz and so I probably hung out with Charlie more than anybody because we were just jazz freaks so we would go out and have dinner and then go hear some music in a city to hear jazz and then often I would set up a gig and he would come and play with me. So it was great. And you get to know their kids and their grandkids and their wives. So it's this big family but it's a great production but also it's a big traveling family. It's very special. It's a really unique situation and luckily I feel close to them in a way, as close as you can to people who are so famous. You know? Like, but it's in a very inviting, relaxed vibe and they keep, luckily knock on wood they've had me back all these years and so it's been great to have this gig for so long.

MR: When one of the tours ends do you speculate on will they do this again? They keep doing it again, don't they?

TR: But I really look at the end of every tour that that's the last one because I can't — first of all they're almost 80 — Charlie unfortunately died at 80. Mick's, they're turning 79 this year. So it's kind of and it's their 60th anniversary tour. 60 years of doing this. So it's like incredible, and you know going back to the surprises, Mick of course — you see a guy that's that age running around stage and you think how does he do it? Well because he eats right, he has a trainer on the road, he exercises, he's in incredible shape. So it's kind of almost like an inspiration realizing hey you know you're approaching 80 you don't have to sit in the chair in the corner of your room and just read a book and be feeble. I mean you can be active and moving, and he's proof of that. I mean he takes care of himself and he's really diligent about being careful with his body and taking care, and he practices, he took voice lessons even in his late 60s or whatever, he started getting a vocal

coach because you realize hey, to keep this together warming up and all of that — so he really is like dedicated to — I think they're better now than they were in a way.

MR: Wow. 60 years. You've played with a lot of other pop artists we'll call it. If you have Spotify on or Sirius radio things come on the radio and you go, "I think I was on that." Does that happen to you?

TR: It has, where I'll be like, "Oh yeah I forgot about doing that." It has happened where like I think that — is that even me? You know like it could be me. Because I did a lot of recordings in New York with different acts and different performers and artists and stuff. And I often remember most things but then yeah, something slips. Yeah I did that or even — but it's kind of a cool thing to have the experience of performing with so many people over the years and, you know, being influenced by their music and then getting a chance like to play — like I got a chance to record with Elvin Jones who is like arguably one of the greatest musicians who ever lived on any instrument, but then — and I haven't told this ever publicly but a couple of my close friends know this but again, like until I was 50 accepting people saying we enjoyed the night and I can say thank you. When I recorded with Elvin he said, "Well I'm going on the road soon, make sure you give my wife your information because we would like to take you on the road. Now this was in my 30s. What I heard was you record with John Coltrane. What could I possibly do? I did not go, I did not give her my number, because I was like I'm not ready. So I got a chance to play with him but I didn't travel with him and I look back at that as like one of the greatest mistakes of my life because it was like he must have heard something that was, you know, enough for him to say would you like to go on the road with us. And I was like man, but at that time in my life I was like well I'm not ready for this gig. It's Elvin Jones. But now I look at it and you know he's not here anymore and it's like — you know so I wouldn't make that same choice.

MR: Would that have been like I remember having albums with him and Joe Farrell — two tenors?

TR: Yeah.

MR: Was that a situation that you were in when you played with him? Like no chordal instrument?

TR: No this particular thing — he wasn't even leading the thing it was like he was a side person like myself but so it was like really a great combination of people: Gary Bartz, Christian McBride, Kenny Werner, so it was kind of a cool thing. It was like three horns, rhythm section, and he was on it, this singer Roseanna Vitro, and it was like, so we started talking and so we're both from the Detroit area, talking about — he's older than me obviously but people that he knew and that I played with when I was growing up, and so it was just a great thing. And he was such a sweet person. And he was like, you know,

"We're going on the road soon, give her your number." Because we need — because it was like between saxophone players. It was after Pat LaBarbera had stopped playing with him, who was a great musician from Upstate New York. And it was just like I wasn't ready. In my mind I wasn't — first of all I'd never be ready. He's Elvin Jones. But man, I'm glad I got the experience and I would have loved to have played six nights a week.

MR: You're the second person who said he was such a sweet person. And I got stuck with this image — I saw him once many years ago in Washington, DC I think, and you know he was playing and he was sweating and he had this look on his face of just this intensity. And I sort of made this assumption that he was not a sweet person because he didn't look it at that point. So I'm happy to hear —

TR: Oh, and I got to see him live when I still lived in Detroit and he came and played Baker's Keyboard Lounge, one of the famous clubs in the world. And I got — and a couple of my friends were in town so I was this close to him. I mean we sat right by the drumset. Because he plays with the intensity — and he actually broke the head of the snare. Because he just hits the ever loving piss out of the instrument. But you know after who we played with, all those musicians, first of all growing up and playing with all those guys in Detroit, you know, then moving to New York, then playing with Coltrane, having played all that music I think that someone like that, and I try to do the same, it's like every night you give up everything you have to the music. And I think that's why he had that, you know the sweating and the — he just was like giving every ounce of himself every note, every phrase, every — so like that, but then when I was there and I was sitting with my friends, you know I was young at the time. And he saw us there and he knew we were fans. And he came over and sat with us. Because we were like afraid to approach Elvin Jones. But he was like — I can see you guys are musicians. And he came over and sat, and he talked for like an hour. It was just like oh my God this is our hero came to our table and hung with us.

MR: Aw, you can't beat that.

TR: Untouchable. Like you know the gods have just descended.

MR: Sheila Jordan told me a pretty horrific story about the racial atmosphere in Detroit that would have been — she's somewhat older of course, but did you witness anything like that going to those clubs with your father?

TR: Yes, only in the sense of like I often would be the only white person within a few miles, not only of the club but like in the entire neighborhood. And I remember the first time I went, there was a famous trumpet player Marcus Belgrave who kind of was like helped oh like Kenny Garrett, Geri Allen, Robert Hurst, a lot of people played with him and he kind of like continued that lineage of like Donald Byrd and Yusef Lateef and Charles McPherson and all those amazing, you know Elvin and all those Detroit — Joe

Henderson, Pepper Adams — all the people who came through Detroit — Hank Jones. I mean I could go on, the list is so vast. So Marcus was like the guy when I was growing up. So I went and I had met Robert Hurst, Bob Hurst, the bass player and so he said, "Well you can come and sit in." So I was there waiting my turn to sit in you know, I didn't want to just like run up to the stage you know. So at the end of the set it was like the vibe was a little bit like I hadn't met them and it was like you know, but it wasn't so much like — but I swear to God once I played I mean like literally everybody in the room hugged me, not just the band. But like it was like the acceptance of being around music that, for me, black music or African-American culture was like what I grew up on. "Soul Train" you know it was like that's — I wanted to attain to that high level of music. So I think the idea is like I never felt weirdness but like and I was accepted because it was this music. And I remember my father saying, when I was a little kid like 14, 15, 16, when he saw the clubs and the fact that I was able to sit in and play and that a lot of bands were mixed you know, it wasn't just all black or all white and I had very good connections with, in Detroit, with the people that I played with that were bands of mixed, white or black or whatever. And I remember him saying when I was young he goes, "You don't know how lucky you are that you are able to be playing with these great musicians but also racially mixing." And I'm like, "Of course" I said. But I didn't think about it. We're talking about mid-70s, late-70s. I wasn't considering and then realizing as I got — the older I get I realize how still messed up it is, how we're still, in 2022, why is there even an issue with you know like not having, like even still having racially — like you live over there, I live over here, and this distance that exists still. I can't imagine based on the color of your skin or your religion or any of that stuff, it just makes no sense to me and yet we seem to have gotten more polarized in the last few years as politically things are getting crazy. It seems like we're back in the 50s again or something. I can't understand it, but musicians, luckily, don't think about this. We're just like you can play, I can play, let's have fun. I think music and sports is the great connector. Because it doesn't matter what neighborhood you're from, where you grew up, who your parents are, what your religion is, you can kick a ball around let's kick that ball around. You can play, you want to play, you know, "Groovin' High" you know let's play that. And if you play it on that level you meet there, you meet in this high place all the other stuff it just doesn't mean shit. We try to leave all that stuff away but really as musicians we have to, I think if it weren't for music, poetry, you know theater, literature, sports — I mean all of these things that do luckily get us to a great meeting point — if I weren't for that I mean society would be in utter peril. I mean we do have that ability to do that. Most people, just the average person living in a house over there, across the street, it's fair to say that it could even be that they work in an office with another person like if they're a white

person maybe they work in an office with a black person but maybe they would never have gone and had a drink with that person or invited them to their house. Like are you actually friends with another person that doesn't look like you? I don't know. Maybe but probably not. It seems like it's not — I hate to say white or black, but it's not that simple but we just still haven't — well here we are Russia is attacking. Why does war have to happen? And why does there have to be racial discrimination? Why does there have to be even the question? And yet they're even talking about now how do you even — people are not even willing to talk about history as it happened. Like even the history that just happened in the 60s with Martin Luther King Jr. Like are you not willing to at least look at the reality of racial discrimination over the past years? Forget about slavery which is the most horrific thing ever. You know slavery, the Holocaust, I mean these are like the most horrific things that have ever happened in human existence. But then that happened, right? Let's talk about that. Like you're a white person, you didn't do that personally. You weren't responsible for that, but do you have a responsibility to at least assess like hey this is part of — this actually happened. People are wanting to erase history even at present, even though it's happening right now. Look at the attack on the Capitol. They don't want to look at that as even — "Oh it wasn't that bad." Actually it was horrific. The people are not willing to even address history so I can see why they don't want to think about — "Oh I wasn't there, I didn't do that." Well no but moving forward how can we change the outlook? What can you do as a person to make sure that not only is it not happening now but it never happens again.

MR: These circumstances from last night I got to hear a number of your original compositions and you seem to be affected by certain occurrences and then able to express your reaction to them in music, which you mentioned this incident about twenty years ago in Paris. When you sit — and you said there was a little piano after this subway incident. And I don't know if you can describe how that emotion — probably shock — translates into a composition?

TR: Well again I feel it's just the music is there and you know whether it's like I'm just capturing it and not getting in the way of it, which is kind of what happened in that situation where this song I wrote, the song "Saint Michel" which is based on that you know, 70 or so people being killed. And had it not been a beautiful day, if it had been raining I would have been on that train because it was so nice I'm going to walk. It's going to take me an hour but I'm going to be outside, Paris the greatest city for walking maybe besides Rome. It's like one of those places where you can get lost and spend hours just — oh let's go down here. Just so thankfully it was a gorgeous day you know. But like knowing that that happened I got back to my friends, it literally was a toy piano the size of like the Linus thing, you know it was like maybe four octaves and it was out of tune

but I wrote that song because it just was like, it just came out, I didn't think actually, it really just came out. And that's happened a number of times in my life where it's just like I feel these things happen. In fact my mother died really tragically very quickly, and she used to talk about guardian angels. And so I wrote a song called "Guardian Angels" that came out on one of my records and then so she used to talk about this that my brother who died was like watching over me. So then I remember I did a lot of work with this fado singer Ana Moura, and it was just after my mother died I wrote this song and I didn't have any lyrics to it, and I didn't title it but I wanted to write this song for Ana because fado music is so powerful and so passionate and I really love it. So I wrote this song for the recording and her producer, the guy who plays guitar for her, Jorge Fernando, who is amazing, I sent it to them so that they could learn it and he goes, "Well can I put lyrics to this?" I said, "Well sure." So I didn't say anything about the song, what it was about or even my feeling, I just sent the song. He gets it and he starts writing lyrics. I get there, I flew to Lisbon, they had already recorded the guitar, the Portuguese guitar, they recorded her vocal. I was just there then and I was like wow, that's really beautiful. What are the lyrics? And he said, "Well you know my feeling was I call this 'Velho Anjo' which is fallen angel. And I immediately got chills. And he said, "The lyrics are about an angel that's dying slowly and the feathers are coming off the wings." I'm getting chills thinking about it because — so you talk about what music does, not only to me but to like, that that person on the other side of the world felt something in the music with just the notes and the chords. That that translated to him and he put that into lyrics without me even saying a word, just the feeling — so it was like okay that exists so that is there with just in the notes, without any lyrics. He put the lyrics to it — I said you can't imagine what you just did for me. Like that — even if I would have told you but so these feelings are there. We musicians, we can capture that.

MR: I've often wondered, song titles can be obvious or is it possible to write a tune and say I don't know what to call this. And the fact that you hadn't titled it left that opening for him perhaps, or maybe he would have gone there anyway but it's a great story.

TR: It was the combination of my mother just dying and like you know that feeling of like, and then thinking how would this work with a fado singer, knowing she would just bring so much passion to the song. But that was it. But most of my music is written thinking about a person in my life or an experience that I've had and that I try not to get technical with my music in the sense like I'm going to do this slick thing. It's more about like this particular feeling that I have. And almost none of them have lyrics.

MR: So the diverse things you've done in your career, I had mentioned earlier on these three videos, and you went from "Jazz Griots" [scats] that lick in there; and then the gypsy band from Budapest; then to trading licks with a flamenco dancer. Are these projects and

directions simply the product of your big ears, your curiosity, or are they sometimes directed by economics, what's happening in the business now? I mean what goes into these projects, which I imagine are never easy — I want to assemble this group of people and do this particular kind of music?

TR: It's never easy and I don't ever think about the money part of it. And I probably should if I was more wise that way I would maybe get a lot more money but all of the projects are just like this is what I want to do and somehow I'm going to make it happen somehow, like the "Jazz Griots" is just like this project with Jordan Walker-Pearlman and he's a film director in L.A. And only because I was on a flight going from New York to L.A. I was sitting next to a gentleman who is a producer and he's a lawyer but he's also a film producer. So he finds interesting projects to do. And he actually did a really amazing film called "Equal Means Equal" about women's rights. And he's just one of these incredible humans that like — and ironically I was sitting in my seat on the aisle and it was like one of those things right before the door shut I thought great, I'm going to have a whole row to myself to L.A. Right before the door shut this guy comes in with his son and they sit next to me. But I was actually wearing this hat, and you know he goes, "Oh that's a really cool hat." I said, "Oh well thank you." So anyway that started the conversation and he goes, "Oh I like hats." I said, "You want to try it on?" Anyway he said, "I've never worn that —" anyway, that started the conversation. "What do you do?" I didn't even talk about the Rolling Stones, I'm a musician. Anyway well I'm going all the way to L.A. talking the whole flight and he was like, "Well I'm actually producing a film and we're doing this, we're showing it for the first time out." He says, "Why don't you come to the film?" I said, "Well I'm doing a recording so I can't." "Oh, well here's my card" and it turns out our houses were near each other. "Let's have lunch when we get back." "Okay cool." So now we're leaving the airplane, "Well have fun." So now we're waiting for our bags to come off the turnstile. Now L.A. is huge, right? So then we're like okay, "Where are you going? Well what's your hotel? Well I'm staying at this hotel. Wait a minute, you're at the same hotel?" Now I'm staying at this hotel because it's two blocks away from the recording studio, Capitol Studios and they have that famous round building where Frank Sinatra recorded and even The Beatles. So for me it was convenient. For him he was way on the other side and he was like oh I just picked it 'cause it looked like an interesting hotel. So I'm like wow. I said, "Look I have to go there, we'll share the taxi." Now we're talking again. Then I get to meet his wife who is meeting him at the hotel, so we had breakfast. It was like, then it became like because I had this connection with him I told him about my idea for the "Jazz Griots." He goes, "I think that sounds really interesting. I'd like you to meet this film director. And first of all I don't believe anybody who says anything in the business, whether it's film or music, because I think

they're just like being nice. Turns out he was being nice and he got back to New York, sure enough I met with this director Jordan Walker-Pearlman. He goes, "I hear you have ideas for movies." And I actually took out a list of like ten ideas. And he looks at these ideas and he goes, "I think we should do that one first, what do you think?" I said, "Yeah." He goes, "Okay let's start." And believe it or not we filmed already two and then right before the pandemic so we're trying to now start again. But it's my idea that African-American culture, music, has to be recognized as how brilliant it actually is rather than you know like films that are made about jazz the concept is you know, oh drugs and alcohol. You know it's like, rather than wait a minute — to play music to that level like Elvin Jones or Jack DeJohnette or Miles Davis or Wayne Shorter or Duke Ellington, you have to be unbelievably brilliant to be able to play at that level that brilliantly. And I want white people to know how brilliant they are. So in their own words like the filming of the music but then also capturing them talking about music, their life, so that documentation of these musicians are still alive and we lost a lot of when Jimmy Heath died and Barry Harris — a lot of musicians that we were trying to get passed away so we're running against the clock a little bit. Sorry that was so long but you know so, yeah, all these projects are great, and the flamenco. In fact because I was in Lisbon with this fado singer Ana Moura we had just finished that recording that I talk about and I saw that Sara Baras, the famous dancer that's on my recording film, I saw that she was performing in Madrid and they were like, "Let's go." So at like one o'clock in the morning we left Lisbon and drove to Madrid all night. We arrived at like seven o'clock in the morning, went to this friend's house and we just hung out and then I was going to go see Sara, this was a Thursday night or whatever. They were playing for a week there. As it turns out then I stayed in Madrid Thursday, Friday, Saturday, Sunday, then I started hanging out. They invited me onstage then I performed Thursday night with them, Friday, Saturday, Sunday. That began my association because of that connection like taking an opportunity like I'm not going to miss out on recording with Elvin — I missed that but I'm not going to miss — I'm taking every opportunity I can to do the things that I want to do while I'm still here.

MR: Three cheers for serendipity.

TR: Yeah. It's like if you want to do something just do it. So then I realized hey, you know what? The worst thing somebody could say is no. Like okay, I asked. But maybe doesn't mean no, maybe it just means no right now but maybe in two months it could be a yes, or maybe — but most people said yes. So if you ask —

MR: You said yes to me.

TR: Absolutely.

MR: When you do your taxes at the end of the year, let's say now, and 25 years ago, have you noticed a significant change in how you're able to make a living, with all the different things you do — has it shifted if you look at you make so much from studio, I make this — how has it changed for you?

TR: A drastic change. I mean in fact before the Stones gig primarily I was just in New York working the studio, doing even sometimes Broadway shows, recording sessions for whoever — it could be a jingle for a commercial for a T.V. commercial. It could be a record date for a particular person, or live gigs or whatever. And then, 'cause I had young children at the time I was trying not to travel as much. So I was just making a pretty good living just right in New York. Then the Stones gig came up then I was on the road quite a bit. I was already on the road doing my own things and then the Stones gig became more — then it was like more on the road. Then it was like the Stones and then my things which are again on the road. So then I was leaving the New York scene more and more and more. But then even the recording scene changed over the years too — not as many — like you'd show up on a record date and it would be like a big group, like a full big band or like an orchestra. That's becoming less and less and less. And then also the weird thing is you have the Rolling Stones gig which has been incredible but then sometimes they'll tour — we'll do like let's say six months. And then maybe take a year off or three months and then take nine months off. So there's a lot of time where I'm actually in New York but people will run into you on the street and they'll go, "Oh are you still out with the Stones?" And I'm like, "Well yes but I'm here for like four months so I could work." So but the idea is like oh you're always away, you're always out. So yeah, it's a funny balance so you kind of like — when you're in New York then you have to show up on the scene and be seen in a way — like oh you're here, okay well I didn't know you were here, well yeah I'm here. So then but then also so the more the things that I do are more my own projects so you had to kind of design your own — you kind of have to make the phone ring yourself, making these projects happen because — out of necessity, out of desire, passion.

MR: Do you still get called for a club date? Like oh we need some background jazz for a cocktail party? You still get those calls and do you take them?

TR: Not so much anymore. Once in a great while I'll — if I'm — I was on a flight once going from Sweden back to the U.S. and this lady was sitting next to me who turns out to be a really famous photographer and her thing was doing these lions, a pride of lions in Africa that she had followed for many years. And we had an interesting conversation and she was going to get married and she wanted me to fly to Africa for the wedding and play with my East Gipsy band from Budapest in Africa. I'm like wow that sounds interesting, I've never been to Africa, why not? As it turns out they couldn't make it and so anyway

the wedding then became in Sweden. And then she said, "Well instead of your East Gipsy band, can you bring" she goes, "the theme of our wedding is actually Italian music, like an Italian theme" she goes, "and actually specifically Sicilian." I said, "Well I actually have friends that have a Sicilian jazz band" I said, "I could bring them." She goes, "Wow." And then it turns out like, 'cause I have all these good friends, in Toronto, Detroit, and Sicily and so we all met in Sweden to play this gig. So Detroit, Toronto, New York, Sicily, meet in Sweden to play this concert. So it was like for a wedding but like really kind of a concert in the restaurant where the wedding was. It was really cool. So those kind of things I will take.

MR: Yeah I guess I was thinking more like the Elks Club in Passaic, New Jersey. That's some club date.

TR: Yeah it was very cool. So the Elks Club not so much, but I did those as a kid with my dad's band.

MR: I wanted to follow up way back, and you talking about sitting in in some of the places in Detroit when you were fairly young. How did you prepare to be ready for those moments? Because getting asked to sit in and then you get onstage and, "Well how about 'Nardis'." "No I don't know that one." Was there a way to get ready for that or did they let you suggest a tune?

TR: Well luckily there was a really cool jazz club in Toledo, Ohio called Rusty's. Her name was Rusty Monroe, and she had this club for many, many, many years. And she cooked the food. And I think I remember once like as she got older and she was telling me about how long it took for her to actually start making money as an owner of a jazz club. Because it was a very popular place, a lot of musicians who came through town — Joe Henderson played there, you know, and all the Detroit musicians would come down because it was really close, it was like less than an hour drive from Detroit to Toledo. So at that club, that's where I first started going with my father who would drive me there. And there was a guy named Eddie Abrams, an old musician, and he would let all the young people come and sit in, like all of us who were 13, 14, 15, 16, like Ron Oswanski was playing when I started playing there when I was getting older, Ron was, he just turned 48 and so there's 12, 13 years' difference. So when he was a kid he would then come sit in with me. So I figured that's how you learn. So Eddie would let me sit in for playing a blues and I would take a song that I would know and he'd go "What do you want to play, what do you know?" "How about this" "Okay let's do that." So he'd let me sit in. So as a kid, and then this guy named Claude Black, another pianist from the area let me sit in. So like Cass Harris, this trumpet player from Detroit, he would be playing. So they would let me sit in — Gene Parker, Jimmy Cook, then more, like I say Marcus Belgrave — so then you learn more and more tunes. And they were kind enough to let

me, as a kid — what did I know, nothing. You know so they were very inviting, very like hey what do you know? So it was like okay, so the next time I go I'm going to learn two more songs, then three. Then you start learning more songs. And then eventually then I started playing with his band you know. In fact last night I did something and I ended this song a certain way and Ron says, "It sounds like an Eddie Abrams ending." You know? So it was kind of a cool thing, because he had a particular thing and then there was another organist, a pianist that I used to play with in Detroit, just like a certain way of playing and vibe from the Detroit sound. It had its own thing.

MR: I wonder if that ending was [scats] because you did that at the end of "Bye Bye"

TR: "Bye Bye Blackbird?"

MR: And I thought wait, what is that, what is that?

TR: Well you know you're ending the tune and it's like okay you sound like a band, even though we hadn't played together as a band, so it was like that makes it sound like —

MR: You know I loved the moment — audience members sometimes don't know these kind of little things that go on, but I think it was in "Willow Weep for Me" and the form had gone to its conclusion, I think it was an alto solo and I saw you like four beats before you stood up and you said something to Ron and the band went to the bridge instead of back to the top. So I'm pretty sure you said, "Bridge." And that's so, I love the onstage etiquette and the learning of the craft and how things work. I don't have a question except it was cool.

TR: No it's one of those things because like I played the melody and then Mike played an alto solo and it was like I didn't need to solo. It was like the song was long enough. I was okay with just playing the melody and then Mike took the solos like hey let's take the bridge out, we don't need more than that. And yeah so that's like, you know, why make a tune ten minutes when it could be — say as much as you need in five.

MR: Well I'm pretty sure you made musical history last night because I'm going to guess that there's never been a medley of "Willow Weep for Me" into "I Can't Get No Satisfaction" into the "Beer Barrel Polka." So congratulations.

TR: Wow. And I did not plan that in any way it just — oh my God well I realized 'cause we were going to go until ten o'clock. And I looked at my watch and it was like oh so maybe we were in "Willow Weep for Me" at like ten to ten because I didn't want to go too much past that or whatever, and I thought well I'll play "Satisfaction" 'cause if there are Stones fans there they want to do that, so we went into that and I saw Al in the front again and the accordion was still out and I thought well how do we get Al up again. And then he comes up and I didn't think about the "Beer Barrel Polka" but he was playing. And Ron was saying, "Just play on C." And I thought well but you know he's trying to think how can I play and I thought you know what? Everyone knows this polka. Certainly Al would

know it, and I know Ron knows it and I used to play polkas in my dad's band 'cause that's one thing, you have to play rock, you have to play Irving Berlin, and you've got to play a polka because somebody might want to dance to that. So I just thought well if I play that Al's going to be able to jump in, which he did. So it was like — again how do you make it work with all — here you have one of the Polka Kings there, you've got to have him play a polka.

MR: I love the end. Not everybody would be able to do that, like well say I'm in this key the melody, and then you do that boom in your head like in an instant.

TR: Well I was trying to think of another polka that would be even more un — sort of like obscure that like Al would be like wow you know that? But in my head I was like also it's getting late and at ten o'clock I thought okay surely everybody in the room would know that and that's why when Ron did that then everyone could join and sing. So then it became like the whole room could be part of it.

MR: Yeah I commented to someone as we were going out the door I said, "I bet you didn't expect the night was going to end like that." It was terrific. Audience communication. And I think you — it's obvious you learned from your father and maybe even from the Stones like about the entertainment factor involved in presenting music. I saw it.

TR: Well I mean I try my best not to be like — you hate to say — well like you said you know one of the great ballads, "Willow Weep for Me" to the Stones' that's one of the most famous songs ever, "Satisfaction" has been covered by everyone from Aretha Franklin to Stevie Wonder to — well it's just so famous, to the "Beer Barrel Polka" — everyone who knows a polka that's probably the most well known polka. So it's almost like I'm trying not to make it too kitsch or too like I'm not trying to go like you know ultra entertainment but it was like on that night, in that room with those people who were part of the mix, I mean how often are you going to have a polka accordion player sitting in the front with his accordion out and not make that part of the night? It's like so — or a different night would be a different thing. You know like 'cause I'm always if I have a friend that's there I will always invite them onstage because then it brings a new element to the band you know. So I try to do what is happening right then, because that's the most important thing, and I was mentioning this to Mr. Domenico today, we just had a cup of coffee before coming over here and there was talking about how nice it was to play in a small venue, even though there wasn't that many people, some of the most beautiful evenings of sharing experiences are in small places. Because 50,000 people is amazing but then after the gig you're not going to go across the street and have a bar — have a beer at with the people who just saw you and really develop like a community with the community of people who live there. But then also to include that, and one of the most incredible nights of my life was with this group of Roma musicians from Budapest, we

went to Romania to play a gig at this really cool venue, small place, and it was such a nice night we moved it out to the back deck because it was a full moon, perfect weather, about a hundred people sitting, it was ultra quiet it was like you could hear a pin drop. And people were so — it was a totally acoustic, no amplification, acoustic bass, acoustic piano, acoustic drums and it was like the connection with the audience with this beautiful night and all the people afterwards, we hung for hours talking to the local people. It was like those are the nights that are the most special because you're not only connecting with the people on the stage who I have this great association with, but then oh my God you get to meet interesting people from Romania who love music and art and you talk about culture and literature, how about this book, and you're like wow, then you really connect with this part of the world.

MR: This has been a wonderful conversation, I'm really glad we could have it. I'm going to wrap up with an observation about your playing and then I'm going to put you on the spot for a moment. I particularly noticed your wonderful ability to play subtone really down at the bottom of the tenor. And then on the other hand when you played your soprano it was like ballsy. Because I hate when the soprano is played like you're using one lung, that sort of like special — at any rate, I want to know what to wrap up, what do you like about your playing?

TR: Wow that's definitely putting me on the spot. Well I try — the first thing you hear from a person is their voice, right? I mean so whether you're talking or singing or almost like — so you know the appealing nature of sounds, so I feel like okay the first thing you have is like the ability hopefully to translate — and I tell this to young musicians, I've had students over the years, talking about you are the instrument. Because the saxophone is just a piece of metal. You can put a different mouthpiece and different reed, of course everything makes a difference but it doesn't do anything on its own. So I'm playing it so I'm the instrument. I'm breathing life into this piece of metal. So you know I guess what I try to do, and I attempt it, I don't know if it's what I like about my playing but I try, is to make it as much — is humanize the instrument as I can to make it not sound like an instrument so that it's just my voice. That's the idea and with the soprano and what you're noticing when I play soprano I think about it as a trumpet more than the saxophone, because I started on trumpet and because my dad played the trumpet, and I even hold it straight out like a trumpet. So I'm more thinking about trumpet and singing than the saxophone. But having said that I also studied a lot of classical and I played in a saxophone quartet playing soprano so we were really doing a lot of string quartet kind of stuff so I really studied that a lot so that's maybe that sound is I'm trying to be really focused on the sound of the soprano. The tenor was my first instrument so I end up thinking about you know the tenor sometimes is just like this beautiful like cello

sounding thing and I'm playing a wooden mouthpiece so I try to have the like low resonance of — so I don't know, I mean I do my best to humanize it and, you know, in all of this thing I should just maybe end with saying about this ensemble that I have called the Universal Spirits Ensemble and it's a group of musicians — it was originally for the idea of the conflict that was happening with the Israeli-Palestinian-Lebanese because I figured okay this is thirty years ago but now the world is just everything is crazy everywhere including in this country. So the band is like Israeli, Palestinian, Lebanese, Afghani, South African, Cuban, Puerto Rican, so it's like a really mixed group of people, not really talking about religion or politics but just like these — the world is playing together. So the idea is to go around the world into smaller communities where maybe somebody lives two hours away from a big city but maybe they won't go to that city, I want to take the city to them, take the world to them teaching young kids to see them maybe like in a community with like a high school kid and maybe have this young flute player playing with a South African and an Afghani and a Palestinian musician and maybe that changes her life forever and maybe that changes that community to like last night in this small community, you know, how do you connect with that community. So we're creating ambassadors for peace and goodwill across the world. So we're playing in New York April 6th at the great place called Drom, D–R-O-M — and President Carter invited us to play at the Carter Center so we played there. So hopefully that group can do more as it comes — that's what I'm focusing on is that ambassadorship of goodwill through this music.

MR: A tradition of that with jazz ambassadors. So thank you for today and for last night. And congratulations on your career so far and whatever you're going to do next.

TR: Oh and you are so kind, Monk, for having — and congratulations all the years you've been doing this, like you've captured a pretty impressive array — I looked at your list I'm like these are all my heroes and favorite musicians. So —

MR: It's been a rather good gig I'll say that.

TR: Thank you for doing this, it's really amazing.

MR: All right.